

Parliament attack, Afzal Guru. What are your views on the death penalty and why didn't you take a decision on some of these pleas?

A. I found that most of the cases which came to me for clemency pertained to people from the lower strata of society. I had sought certain information from the ministry concerned and we are still discussing them. Regarding Afzal Guru, I have not received any papers from the ministry concerned so far.

Q. Is that why you didn't take a decision in his case?

A. If the papers had come to me, I would have processed them for their worth. Before the Government sends me papers of this nature, it has to go through several processes; it has to check with the Cabinet and also the state government concerned. It is going through that process.

Q. So what are your views about the death penalty itself?

A. As President, I have to have only one view. After 25th (the day he laid down office), I will have a different view.

Q. India is at the final stage of signing a civilian nuclear deal with the US. Some political parties and experts have expressed concern that the deal may compromise the country's strategic capability. As someone who was one of the principal architects of our nuclear weapons programme, what would your advice be to the Government now?

A. I believe that for India self-reliance is the only way for nuclear energy. We have to take the thorium route since we have large reserves of it available. A good amount of research

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is essential. Our scientists can lead to thorium-based nuclear reactor for energy production. I believe in them.

Q. Do you think this deal would affect the self-reliance goal?

A. No. The deal does not talk of self-reliance. Self-reliance is a national

A. It's an important point. I believe we have to make the whole reservation issue irrelevant by increasing the number of seats in our colleges—just like engineering colleges which have 20,000 to 30,000 seats. In other areas like bio-science, medicine, management and many specialised fields, we have to add more seats.

Q. Are you concerned about the quality of political discourse in the country? Also, by the lack of focus on some critical issues?

A. Yes, I am concerned, because development is not being talked about as it should be. It is not being given the highest priority in all political decisions. For instance, no political party has defined which year India would become economically developed. Nor have they discussed how competitive India should be compared to other countries. We are now ranked 43 in the competitive index; so when do we get to be among the top five? I have defined in Parliament that politics is equal to political politics plus development politics. Every political leader—legislators and parliamentarians—has to spend at least 70 per cent on

developmental politics. But the reverse is taking place. I wish our electorate would choose leaders on the basis of their developmental track record.

Q. Post-presidency, what are your plans?

A. I will be teaching and doing research in five institutions.

Q. If at some point there is need for a consensus candidate to be a prime minister, will you accept the post if it was offered to you?

A. This is a juicy question for you. But it looks hypothetical to me. My plate is already full with the mission I just described to you. ■

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policy and programme. We have to work on that.

Q. One of the major issues that came up during your presidency was the issue of reservation for OBCs in educational institutions and also for the Muslim community. How do you view the whole issue of reservation?

"If the President has VISION, he can PROPAGATE it and nobody can prevent that. In fact, the NATION will welcome it."